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first unit to receive and start using the UAVs was Russia's

Editor's Pick

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Tags: editor, Eurosatory,

Northern Fleet, the publication notes, which is typically regarded as one of Russia's higher performing formations.

KNDS, Loras
howitzer

The units there are responsible for much of Russia's nuclear submarines and elements of its nuclear triad. They will use the Forpost-R to conduct surveillance and reconnaissance over Russia's borders and the Barents Sea. Russia's other fleets have also begun to receive the UAVs, according to the article, which indicates that it is seen as a suitable platform for maritime reconnaissance.

Russia's naval forces and marine infantry have been experimenting with UAVs for some time, using them to launch from ships and coordinate fire support during amphibious landings. That is usually carried out by the smaller Orlan-10, however. The entry of Forpost into service follows another recent announcement that the Russian navy is establishing drone units and indicates that uncrewed platforms will play an increasingly important role in Russia's operations at sea.

According to a May article also published by Izvestia, there will be an 'unmanned regiment' in each of Russia's fleets, of which there are currently four as well as two flotilla (the Northern Fleet, the Pacific Fleet, the Black Sea Fleet, the Baltic Fleet and the Dnieper and Caspian Flotillas). The

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The Forpost-R has been used over Ukraine and in Syria, although the Russian forces tend to wait for a more permissive and UAV-friendly airspace before deploying them. The large size of the Forpost means that it has occasionally been shot down, both in Ukraine and in Syria. However, there are times when it appears to make a significant impact on the fighting on the ground, and has been employed extensively in the Sumy region, where footage appears to show guided engagements against vehicles, it can also provide laser designation for the Krasnopol laser guided artillery round.

Tech profile: Forpost-R

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The Forpost-R is a relatively large UAV weighing 500 kg with a range of 250 km and the ability to carry munitions. It can fly at altitudes of 6,000 metres and up to speeds of 180 km/h with a cruising speed of 120 km/h. It provides an endurance of 18 hours and is designed to provide reconnaissance and strike capabilities over long border areas. It has a wingspan of 8.55 metres and a length of 5.85 metres, and requires a runway for take-off and recovery.

Armament can include bombs or guided missiles like the KAB-20, which is a laser guided bomb weighing 21 kg with a 7 kg warhead with a range of 8 km, according to Militarnyi, a Ukrainian publication. The payload is variably reported as 60 kg – 100 kg, with one image showing a Forpost carrying four KAB-20s, indicating the payload capacity is at least 84 kg. The UAV carries electro-optical and infrared imaging as standard, and radar-based reconnaissance systems can be fitted in place of the optical suite. Each Forpost system includes three UAVs and a ground control station, so that the UAVs can be flown in orbits to maintain a presence over a target region.

The design is based on the Israeli Searcher Mk II, which was exported to Russia in after 2008 as the country's armed forces tried to process the lessons of the Georgian

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that it can resource despite sanctions. It was flown for the first time in 2019.

Calibre comment

Russia's forces are effective and capable users of UAVs and other uncrewed or remotely operated platforms. They have demonstrated the ability to design and produce a range of loitering munitions and one-way attack drones that meet different purposes from engaging singular vehicles to levelling buildings. The development appears to be driven both from the top-down, with Russia's Defence Minister Andrei Belousov announcing a new unmanned branch of the armed forces in 2024, as well as bottom up. For instance, Russian volunteers have developed and deployed at least 50 Courier UGVs, which do not appear to have any official MoD funding. This shows how some of the developments in tactics and technology are the result of frontline innovations, which complicates attempts to assess what portion of the developments in uncrewed systems will survive the war. Regardless, it does seem that Forpost-R is here to stay, and it stands to reason that it will be a valuable addition to the Russian naval forces, supporting their operations up to and including high intensity warfare.

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